

Chapter 162 Extra Chapter Four

Leaving Jiang Li and Jiuying to help the old man collect his beans, Ning Fuyi took Su Mo and hurried back to the Tranquil Mountain Palace first. She carefully set down Su Mo, who was pale with fright from sword riding, and wiped the sweat from her forehead with her hand.

"Wait for me here. I'll feel at ease only if I can see you. Don't go anywhere." Ning Fuyi gestured gently, then pulled over a rattan chair for her to hide in the shade under the blooming cotton rose tree.

"I'll be right back," she said.

Su Mo released her grip on Ning Fuyi's sleeve, her eyes curved like crescents as she pointed to Ning Fuyi and then Chu Qingqiu, placing the back of her hand under her chin: "I'll wait for you."

Ning Fuyi looked at her with heartache, then turned around and walked quickly toward the corridor bridge over the water.

That snow-white graceful figure stood in the lakeside pavilion, the wind lifting her skirt and hair like an elegant crane. Ning Fuyi, jingling with all her ornaments, walked behind her and poked the white crane's nape.

The two standing together were well-matched, like the sun and moon sharing the sky.

Su Mo stared blankly, not even noticing flowers falling into her collar.

"You're angry," Ning Fuyi said, opening her innocent phoenix eyes wide and bumping Chu Qingqiu's shoulder with her own, only to have her dodge aside.

"I'm not angry," Chu Qingqiu said, looking down at her reflection in the lake.

She truly wasn't angry, only when she saw the two embracing, her heart filled with unbearable frustration. Afraid she might lose composure in public, she fled in panic.

However, the moment she fled, she knew she had already lost composure.

"I like Chu Qingqiu, Su Mo, the Divine Venerable Chu Ling, and everything in this world that belongs to you." Ning Fuyi pulled her sleeve, drawing her close while stuffing something into her hand.

Chu Qingqiu picked it up and found it was a woven grass insect.

"It can even chirp," Ning Fuyi pulled the insect's tail, and it made squeaking sounds.

Chu Qingqiu's eyelashes trembled, and the corners of her mouth softened slightly: "Childish."

"I know." Chu Qingqiu learned to shrug like Jiuying. "I never doubted it. Go draw me some hot water, with last night's flower dew, heated up."

"Alright." Ning Fuyi nodded obediently, then made the grass insect chirp a few more times. Only after being pushed by Chu Qingqiu did she leave with a laugh.

She returned to Su Mo's side. Su Mo was still sitting quietly in the same place—as long as Ning Fuyi didn't say to leave, she would sit there for eternity.

Ning Fuyi crouched in front of her, using her hand to brush away the hair dampened by sweat and helping her remove her veil: "Su Mo, this veil is too hot, and there are no strangers here anyway."

"Do you want me to accompany you, or would you like to wander around by yourself?" Ning Fuyi said gently.

Su Mo naturally wanted her to stay, but she quickly looked toward Chu Qingqiu's silhouette, then smiled and raised her hands: "I'll wander around by myself."

Only after Ning Fuyi's figure disappeared did she withdraw her longing gaze, covering the bright red birthmark on her face and slowly standing up to walk toward the lakeside pavilion.

Chu Qingqiu naturally heard her movement but didn't turn around, even feeling somewhat nervous.

In her trance, she suddenly heard the sound of shifting bricks and a low exclamation from behind. White silk immediately shot from Chu Qingqiu's sleeve, pulling the person who had nearly fallen into the water away from the water's edge.

Her luck in the mortal realm was indeed fraught with disasters. Chu Qingqiu thought coldly, then slowly retracted the white silk and waited for Su Mo to steady herself.

"Thank, thank you." The halting voice sounded. Chu Qingqiu nodded with a stern face, indicating it was nothing.

Su Mo walked to her side, her eyes alternately falling on the water surface and timidly glancing at Chu Qingqiu, back and forth several times.

Finally, Chu Qingqiu had no choice but to raise her hands, familiar gestures flowing like clouds: "Is there something?"

Su Mo quickly shook her head, then after a while, bit her lip and gestured while speaking clearly: "You are Chu Qingqiu."

"Mm." Chu Qingqiu replied.

"She told me about you." Su Mo's eyes were clear. "She said you're very capable, even more capable than her."

"No one has ever bullied you. You also help many people, and everyone likes you very much."

Chu Qingqiu wanted to say "I remember," but for some reason didn't speak, only remaining silent.

"Do you like her now? She said you didn't love her before." Su Mo seemed to be getting into the habit of talking, her slender fingers never stopping. "But I don't think so, because I love her very much."

Chu Qingqiu's eyes suddenly felt sore. This time she looked at Su Mo, her gaze lingering on the birthmark that was so incongruous with her face, and said softly: "I like her."

"How much do you like her?"

"More than all else in the world."

Su Mo's hands stopped in mid-air, and she didn't say anything more for a long while. Then she smiled faintly and crouched down, putting her hand into the cool water.

Chu Qingqiu also crouched down, her fingertips touching the water surface and creating ripples. After a while, she suddenly discovered that she and Su Mo were playing with the water in exactly the same way.

They both liked to extend one finger and sway it left and right in the water. She slowly opened her eyes wide, feeling a tremor throughout her body.

She looked again at the hair bun on Su Mo's head. A simple wooden hairpin held her hair in place, not the slightest bit askew, flat and evenly inserted in the center, with equal lengths on both sides.

She couldn't help but touch the back of her own head, where a jade hairpin in the same center position was pinned behind her head.

"Chu Qingqiu, you're really wonderful. Su Mo truly envies you so much." Su Mo suddenly spoke.

Chu Qingqiu stopped her movements in a daze. After an unknown amount of time, she also smiled.

"Su Mo is also wonderful."

Su Mo's arrival had caused quite a commotion, but it soon settled into tranquility. For the following half month, Su Mo stayed confined to the side hall, rarely taking a step outside.

Occasionally when she did go out, she would only secretly hide in corners to catch a glimpse of Ning Fuyi before quickly returning to her room. Whenever Ning Fuyi asked about it, she would just smile without saying anything.

The entire Tranquil Mountain Palace maintained this harmony. Just when Ning Fuyi was preparing for their days to continue like this, Jiuying returned with a solemn expression and news.

"Yun Ke says that tomorrow the five stars will return to their proper course, and then the cosmic order will be restored." She stood in the rustling evening wind, sighing as she spoke to Ning Fuyi.

After hearing this, Ning Fuyi remained silent for a long time. After seeing Jiuying off, she slowly climbed the steps and walked up to the building bathed in bright moonlight.

She didn't hide anything but told Su Mo everything in detail. After hearing it, Su Mo also looked normal, only moving closer to Ning Fuyi.

She gazed at Ning Fuyi with reluctance, then extended her arms and groped into Ning Fuyi's embrace, hugging her chest as usual.

"Today, I don't want to sleep. Stay with me until dawn." Su Mo spoke word by word, lifting her face to look at Ning Fuyi, the flower on her cheek blooming in the moonlight.

Ning Fuyi naturally agreed. Then the two sat side by side on the threshold, Su Mo hugging the Shu brocade blanket Ning Fuyi had given her that day, curling up into a ball and leaning in her arms, eyes wide open gazing at the bright moon.

The deep blue sky occasionally had thin clouds that rolled with the wind, obscuring the bright moon. A row of birds flew past under the moon, making it appear incredibly large.

Not far away, in the room with deep candlelight, jade-white wrists turned, and a barely perceptible white light soared upward. The thin clouds soon scattered completely, leaving only the moon.

They really sat like this all night, watching the moon rise and set, dawn winds arise, and rosy clouds spread.

The moment she saw the rosy clouds, Su Mo suddenly opened her mouth.

"I asked, and Chu Qingqiu likes you. I'm relieved." She began to ramble. "She's very strong and treats you very well."

"Oh, there's a box under the bed in my room with things I'm giving to you and Chu Qingqiu."

"Don't forget," she said.

"Don't forget..."

The rosy clouds completely penetrated the cloud layer—it was a bright clear day. The gauze-like night faded away, and sunlight stretched for thousands of miles.

"I won't forget." Ning Fuyi said in a low voice. She sat alone in the original spot, with only the whooshing wind beside her.

Ning Fuyi lowered her head to wipe away tears that had fallen at some unknown time, then supported herself on the door frame to stand up, her legs already numb and sore.

The room next door suddenly made a muffled sound. Ning Fuyi immediately transformed into black mist and squeezed through the door crack, embracing the woman who had bumped into the table: "What happened?"

Chu Qingqiu's eyes were bright red at this moment, obviously having shed tears. She covered her temple with one hand and her bumped knee with the other. Although it didn't hurt that much, tears still fell.

"Does it hurt badly?" Ning Fuyi was so anxious she almost ran in circles, sometimes rubbing her completely uninjured knee, sometimes massaging her brow, busy beyond measure.

Finally, the woman pushed her hands away, turned and curled into her embrace in the same posture as Su Mo, half crying and half laughing as she said something.

"Forcibly stuffing memories like this is too much even for an immortal to bear." She sighed and closed her eyes, Su Mo's sadness not yet dissipating from her mind.

So that's how it was. Only then did Ning Fuyi feel relieved. She gently patted the woman's back, slowly comforting her.

She patted for a long time before the woman stopped crying, nuzzling against Ning Fuyi's neck and wiping all her remaining tears on her shoulder before raising her head with a cold expression.

Her eye corners and nose tip were still as red as spilled crimson ink.

"Su Mo... what did she leave for me?" Ning Fuyi asked.

Chu Qingqiu glanced at her, and the red on her nose tip quickly spread to her face.